

Cautions Best avoided while breastfeeding.

Do not take if allergic to aspirin.

Self-help Use Coughs, p. 310.

Populus tremuloides (Salicaceae)

Quaking Aspen

Description Deciduous, spreading tree growing to 65 ft (20 m). Has oval, slightly sticky buds and round, finely toothed leaves that quiver in the wind.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to North America, quaking aspen prefers damp and moist areas, and grows alongside rivers and in valleys, hedgerows, and groves. It is also widely cultivated in temperate regions. The bark is collected in early spring.

Part Used Bark.

Constituents The bark contains phenolic glycosides (including salicin and populin) and tannins. Salicin and populin are salicylates, substances that have fever-reducing, pain-relieving, and anti-inflammatory properties that are similar to those of aspirin.



Quaking aspen bark contains salicin, a substance with aspirin-like effects.

History & Folklore The Ojibwa people used an oily compound made from quaking aspen and bear fat to treat earache. Other Native Americans used the bark for a variety of purposes, including as an eyewash for sore eyes.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Like willow bark (*Salix alba*, p. 129), quaking aspen bark has widely recognized anti-inflammatory and pain-relieving

properties. It is often taken to treat arthritic and rheumatic aches and pains. It is also used to lower fever, especially when this condition is associated with rheumatoid arthritis. Being stimulant, quaking aspen bark acts as a tonic remedy in the treatment of anorexia and other debilitated states. The bark's significant astringent and antiseptic qualities make it useful for treating diarrhea and the symptoms of irritable bowel syndrome. It is also used to treat urinary tract infections.

Caution Do not take quaking aspen if allergic to aspirin.

Portulaca oleracea (Portulacaceae)

Purslane

Description Succulent annual plant growing to 6 in (15 cm). Has small, thick rounded leaves and small yellow flowers growing in clusters.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Europe and Asia, purslane is now one of the most widely distributed plants, growing from Australia and China to the Americas. Often found growing near water, it is gathered throughout the summer. Wild purslane is the variety chiefly used as a medicine; the golden variety, *P. oleracea* var. *sativa*, is cultivated mostly as a kitchen potherb.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Purslane contains flavonoids, alkaloids, fatty acids (significant omega-3 oil content), terpenoids, polysaccharides, vitamins A, B₁, and C, proteins and minerals (especially calcium).

History & Folklore Purslane's use as a medicinal herb in Europe, Iran, and India dates back at least 2,000 years, and it was probably eaten as a vegetable well before then. In ancient Rome, purslane was used to treat headaches, stomach ache and dysentery, intestinal worms, and lizard bite.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Purslane has long been considered valuable in the treatment of urinary and digestive problems. The diuretic effect of the juice makes it useful in the alleviation of bladder ailments, for example difficulty in passing urine. The plant's mucilaginous properties also make it a soothing remedy for gastrointestinal problems such as dysentery and diarrhea. In Chinese herbal medicine, purslane is employed for similar problems and, additionally, for appendicitis. The Chinese also use the plant as an antidote for wasp stings and snake bite. Used as an external wash, the juice or a decoction relieves skin ailments such as boils and carbuncles, and also helps to reduce fever.



Leaves

Purslane is a good source of vitamins and calcium. It also has antibiotic properties.

Research Purslane is being intensively researched. Extracts of the herb show antioxidant, anti-inflammatory, analgesic, and antidiabetic activity, underlining that fact that purslane is valuable as food and as medicine. The alkaloids have neuroprotective activity and inhibit acetylcholinesterase, making the herb theoretically of use in Alzheimer's disease.

Caution Do not take purslane as a medicine during pregnancy.

Potentilla anserina (Rosaceae)

Silverweed

Description Perennial plant growing to 16 in (40 cm). Has toothed compound leaves that are silvery on the underside, and 5-petaled yellow flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Silverweed is found in Europe, Asia, and North America, where it flourishes in dry grassy places. The aerial parts are collected in late summer, the root at the same time or in autumn.

Parts Used Aerial parts, root.

Constituents Silverweed contains 2–10% ellagitannins, flavonoids, choline, and bitters.

History & Folklore William Withering, the 18th-century doctor who discovered the cardiotonic effects of foxglove (*Digitalis purpurea*, p. 202), recommended a teaspoon of dried leaves to be taken at 3-hour intervals to assuage bouts of malarial fever.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Silverweed's main medicinal value lies in its astringent and anti-inflammatory activity. It makes an effective gargle